inflict such devastating and indiscriminate slaughter upon its own subjects?'.[6]

It was the construction of a rule of colonial difference, with its concomitant reliance on ferocious violence, which also informed colonial penal policy. This is clear from a distinguished historian of the British Indian Empire, Taylor Sherman, who has analysed the study of colonial penal practices across the world.[7] She observes that the first generation of research focussed narrowly on imprisonment.[8] A second generation of such studies, emerging only since around 2004, focussed on capital and corporal punishment as well as policing and the courts. Interestingly, this also included research on the way indigenous people also experienced and interpreted their punishments. A third generation of scholarly study is now needed, however, to develop 'a new focus for the study of colonial punishment', she argues, and one 'which views colonial coercive techniques' as part of imperial 'coercive networks'.[9] This book hopes to be part of that endeavour, focussing as it does on the imperial technique of 'coercive colonial laws' which led to the improper hanging of Bhagat Singh. The coercive colonial legalism arose because, as Taylor Sherman explained in an earlier work, of the changed political circumstances of the 1930s. This meant that '[w]hile the 1920s witnessed a short period of moderate political liberalization, the early 1930s saw a reversal of this trend as the colonial regime cracked down on both a second nationalist civil disobedience campaign and violent revolutionary activities. With the revival of the activities of small groups of revolutionaries in colonial India, these groups were called terrorists in the 1930s . . .'.[10]